Prismatic Analysis of Brexit as a Case Study in Interpretive Divergence

Pre-analysis reflexive declaration

Likely home grammar

My likely “home grammar” for Brexit is closest to an **economic-integration / material-welfare** framework: it privileges macroeconomic and trade/investment signals (GDP, productivity, trade volumes, sector performance) and tends to treat constitutional sovereignty claims as secondary unless they generate measurable institutional or economic effects. This is partly because the most standardised, comparable evidence about Brexit is economic and administrative-statistical rather than directly “sovereignty-measurable”. The bias is methodological as much as ideological: it is easier to stabilise arguments around quantified series than around normative concepts like “self-rule”.

Hardest grammar to operate faithfully

The hardest grammar for me to operate faithfully is the **sovereignty–constitutional autonomy** grammar, not because it is incoherent, but because its primary variable is partly **normative** (what *should* count as decisive) and partly **counterfactual** (what the UK *can now do* with legal autonomy), while many common signals (GDP, trade, net migration) are treated as “implementation noise” or “transitional costs”. This grammar also has a strong rhetorical architecture (“control”, “democratic deficit”, “self-government”) that can be misrepresented if translated too quickly into cost–benefit language.

What I might miss given my analytical position

I may under-detect:

- **Status and recognition dynamics** (how Brexit “means” dignity, humiliation, or reassertion for groups) that are only indirectly observable in economic series.
- **Legitimacy effects** that operate through trust, polarisation, and institutional consent rather than immediate economic outcomes.
- **Positive-sum interpretations** (e.g., “Brexit as capability-building”) that treat short-run friction as a training cost rather than a net loss.

Temporal orientation

My temporal orientation is **mixed but forward-leaning**: I default to assessing **path-dependence** from 2016–2026, but I also attend to how each grammar projects a future (rejoin, reset, divergence, or constitutional rupture). This matters because Brexit’s “meaning” is unusually sensitive to whether a grammar permits “not yet” conclusions.

Observation field declaration

Phenomenon, temporal frame, geographic scope

Phenomenon: The United Kingdom's decision to leave the European Union ("Brexit"), understood as (i) a democratic act (2016 referendum), (ii) a constitutional/juridical process (withdrawal and treaties), and (iii) an ongoing reconfiguration of economic, institutional, and cultural life. The case includes the referendum campaign, formal withdrawal, negotiation and implementation of post-exit arrangements, and downstream consequences.

Temporal frame: 2016 referendum to the present point in this analysis (March 2026). Key institutional transition points include: the referendum (June 2016), Article 50 litigation and parliamentary authorisation (2016–2017), exit and the Withdrawal Agreement entering into force (February 2020), end of transition (December 2020), operationalisation of the Northern Ireland Protocol (January 2021) and later Windsor Framework amendments (announced 2023; implementation changes through 2024), and the UK–EU "reset" summit and cooperation agenda (May 2025).

Geographic scope: The United Kingdom (including internal territorial politics in Northern Ireland and Scotland), the European Union as counterparty, and selected global linkages (e.g., new trade agreements and mobility/travel systems).

Why interpretive divergence occurs in this case

Interpretive divergence is unusually strong here for five structural reasons.

First, **the initiating event was a narrow majority vote** (52–48 in common shorthand; formally 51.9% Leave to 48.1% Remain), so legitimacy was immediately contested despite procedural validity.

Second, Brexit is not one policy but a **bundle of partially separable changes** (trade regime, migration regime, regulatory regime, constitutional identity, territorial settlement). A grammar that treats "sovereignty" as the phenomenon is not analysing the same object as a grammar treating "trade frictions" as the phenomenon—yet both speak the name "Brexit".

Third, **signal attribution is difficult** because the post-2016 period includes major exogenous shocks and measurement breaks (COVID-19, supply chain disruption, the Ukraine war, and trade-statistics discontinuities after January 2021). Even high-quality signals therefore often require modelling choices about counterfactuals and baselines.

Fourth, Brexit is a **meaning-saturated event**: identity, belonging, and moral narratives ("democracy", "betrayal", "freedom", "decline") are not merely commentary but causal forces that shape political behaviour, institutional trust, and policy choices.

Fifth, Brexit has **recursive politics**: later evidence is continuously reprocessed as either (a) confirmation ("Brexit is working"), (b) sabotage/implementation failure ("Brexit wasn't done properly"), or (c) proof of inherent impossibility ("you cannot leave without loss"). This makes closure timing central.

Signal contestation level

Overall, the case has **high signal contestation**:

- **Measurement disputes**: e.g., the Office for Statistics Regulation (OSR) identified large and potentially biased revisions in monthly trade-in-services estimates, reducing "value to users" and requiring caution when using monthly services trade to support strong conclusions.

Major interpretive communities

Interpretive communities (not exhaustive) include:

- **UK constitutionalists / sovereigntists**: often emphasising parliamentary sovereignty, border control, and self-governance as primary goods; commonly narrate economic friction as transitional or as the cost of freedom.
- **Economic integrationists**: business groups, many economists, and pro-EU commentators prioritising market access, investment, productivity, and institutional cooperation; often treat sovereignty claims as symbolic if they reduce welfare.
- **Identity / territorial cohesion analysts**: scholars and practitioners focusing on polarisation, legitimacy, nationalism, and the integrity of the UK union (Northern Ireland's settlement and Scotland's constitutional trajectory).

The boundaries between these communities are porous; individuals can "code-switch" depending on context.

Signal set

The prismatic method holds the empirical input constant. The following signals are the shared "input layer" that each grammar will process with distinct selection rules and weightings.

Core signals

Signal	What it is (time window)	Source (anchor)	Type	Ambiguity / contestation note
Referendum result	17,410,742 Leave (51.9%) vs 16,141,241 Remain (48.1%); turnout 72.2%	Electoral Commission referendum report	Quantitative / discrete	Narrow margin intensifies legitimacy contestation even when procedure accepted.
Campaign governance breach	Vote Leave sanctioned/fined for breaches of electoral law (with later updates on appeals/fines paid)	Electoral Commission media centre	Institutional / legal	Often processed as "illegitimacy" (one grammar) vs "procedural footnote" (another).
Constitutional constraint (Article 50)	Supreme Court (Miller) majority held that an Act of Parliament was required to authorise Article 50 notice	UK Supreme Court press summary	Constitutional / legal	Contestation: "Parliamentary sovereignty affirmed" vs "elite obstruction".
Withdrawal Agreement entry into force	Withdrawal Agreement entered into force 1 Feb 2020; includes Protocol on Ireland/Northern Ireland	European Commission	Treaties / institutional	Often treated as "orderly withdrawal" vs "constraint architecture (NI)".

Trade and Cooperation Agreement (TCA) timing	TCA signed 30 Dec 2020; provisional application 1 Jan 2021; entered into force 1 May 2021	European Commission; UK govt TCA report	Treaties / institutional	“Zero-tariff, zero-quota” can be weighted as success or as offset by non-tariff barriers.
GDP growth to end-2025	Real GDP +0.1% in Q4 2025; annual GDP +1.3% in 2025 (after +1.1% in 2024); services no growth in Q4; production +1.2%	ONS GDP first quarterly estimate (Q4 2025)	Quantitative / macro	Attribution is contested; also “per head” measures matter for welfare.
Real GDP per head	Real GDP per head fell 0.1% for second consecutive quarter in Q4 2025; annual real GDP per head +1.0% in 2025	ONS GDP first quarterly estimate	Quantitative / welfare	Grammars differ on whether per-head welfare is decisive or subordinate to sovereignty/identity.
UK–EU trade level and composition	2024 exports to EU £358bn (41% of exports), imports from EU £454bn (51% of imports); goods exports to EU 18% below 2019 (real), services exports to EU 19% above 2019 (real)	House of Commons Library trade briefing	Quantitative / trade	Brexit + other shocks acknowledged; data collection changes create breaks.
Trade data reliability caveat	OSR finds large revisions (and potential upward bias) in trade-in-services estimates; monthly estimates can have “limited value” to users	OSR trade statistics review	Methodological / meta-signal	A “signal about signals”: affects admissibility/weighting of services trade claims.
Net migration trajectory	Net migration fell from 944,000 (YE March 2023) to 204,000 (YE June 2025); non-EU+ net migration +383,000, EU+ −70,000, British −109,000	ONS long-term international migration (provisional)	Quantitative / demographic	Migration is “control” signal (sovereigntist) and “labour supply” signal (economic).

Northern Ireland governance architecture	NI Protocol came into force 1 Jan 2021; Windsor Framework is amended Protocol; Safeguarding the Union (Jan 2024) revised operation and supported restoration of NI institutions	House of Commons Library briefing	Institutional / territorial	Ontological divergence: some see NI as central to Brexit's meaning; others as a technical annex.
NI democratic consent renewal	NI Assembly voted (Dec 2024) to continue Articles 5–10 arrangements; UK govt treated it as key step and commissioned independent review	UK govt statement; reporting	Institutional / legitimacy	Unionist vs nationalist interpretations differ sharply; "consent" itself is contested.
Scotland constitutional temperature	Ipsos (Feb 2026) finds 51% Yes vs 49% No among likely Yes/No voters in immediate referendum	Ipsos Scottish Political Monitor	Quantitative / identity-constitutional	Polling sensitive to question wording/turnout assumptions; used as "union stability" signal.
Institutional trust and political legitimacy	BSA report: 79% say system of governing could be improved "quite a lot/a great deal"; also records high distrust measures; includes Brexit-linked disenchantment among Leave voters	NatCen (BSA 41 press release)	Quantitative / legitimacy	Trust can be processed as Brexit damage, or as broader governance crisis with Brexit as symptom.
Regulatory divergence indicator	REUL ceased as special category 1 Jan 2024; remaining REUL became "assimilated law"; dashboard lists 6,757 pieces; many unchanged; reform roadmap to June 2026	House of Commons Library REUL briefing	Legal / regulatory	"Freedom to diverge" vs "transaction cost of divergence" is grammar-dependent.
Post-Brexit relationship evolution (reset)	UK–EU summit 19 May 2025: Common Understanding includes youth experience scheme, Erasmus+ association talks, SPS agreement ambition (dynamic alignment),	UK govt summit documentation	Institutional / future-trajectory	Key because it shows "Brexit is not frozen"; but also implies alignment constraints.

	and potential electricity market participation			
Mobility/travel regime shift	EU Entry/Exit System started 12 Oct 2025; phased full operation expected April 2026	GOV.UK; EU travel site	Administrative / cultural	Often framed as “friction” symbol in everyday life; salience varies by grammar.

Counter-signals

Counter-signals are not “extra”; they are integrated as stressors inside each grammar’s processing.

Counter-signal	Why it matters	Source
Services trade resilience	Services exports to both EU and non-EU in 2024 are above 2019 in real terms (+19% EU; +23% non-EU), complicating “trade collapse” narratives	House of Commons Library trade briefing
External trade diversification capacity	UK accession to CPTPP entered into force by 15 Dec 2024 (government framing: tariff-free access for large share of goods exports to CPTPP members)	GOV.UK CPTPP announcement
UK–EU cooperative drift	2025 “reset” agenda aims to reduce frictions (SPS; electricity market exploration), indicating reversibility/renegotiation within Brexit constraints	UK–EU Common Understanding
Net migration fall (recent)	Total net migration fell sharply to 204,000 by YE June 2025, challenging claims of permanently “lost control” (though composition remains salient)	ONS migration bulletin
NI consent mechanism functioning	Democratic consent vote occurred and continuation was agreed, suggesting institutional stabilisation even under contestation	UK govt statement; reporting

Contested signals and per-grammar interpretation

The same item becomes a different “signal” depending on grammar rules. The following are explicitly contested and will be handled in processing.

GDP performance and its attribution (contest): ONS reports modest GDP growth (+1.3% in 2025) and flat-ish quarterly growth (+0.1% in Q4).

- Sovereignty grammar: GDP is a *secondary* signal; weak performance is “transition + global shocks”, and not dispositive.
- Economic integration grammar: GDP (and per-head) is a *primary* welfare signal; underperformance is central evidence of Brexit costs.
- Identity/union grammar: GDP is relevant insofar as it reshapes trust, status, and territorial bargaining power (e.g., Scottish/NI politics), not as an end in itself.

Trade volumes and data comparability (contest): Commons Library flags a structural break (January 2021) in goods trade statistics due to collection changes; OSR flags large revisions in services trade.

- Sovereignty grammar: contestation is used to downweight trade-loss claims and emphasise “new opportunities”.
- Economic integration grammar: measurement caveats are acknowledged, but persistent friction is still inferred from multiple sources and from institutional changes (TCA vs single market).
- Identity/union grammar: trade is processed mainly through lived experience narratives (small business burdens; everyday frictions) and territorial politics (NI).

Migration as “control” (contest): ONS shows both (i) a sharp fall since 2023 and (ii) continued positive non-EU+ net migration with EU+ negative.

- Sovereignty grammar: shift from EU free movement to chosen immigration regimes is a success; composition matters more than total.
- Economic integration grammar: migration affects labour supply and sector capacity; sudden changes can be cost drivers as well as benefits.
- Identity/union grammar: migration is a symbolic boundary signal shaping national identity debates and political alignment, not only labour economics.

Regulatory divergence (contest): REUL becoming “assimilated law” and the reform roadmap to 2026 can be read as liberation or as fragmentation.

- Sovereignty grammar: divergence is the point—evidence of regained lawmaking authority.
- Economic integration grammar: divergence is a trade/investment friction generator unless carefully managed.
- Identity/union grammar: divergence is politically salient insofar as it signals “who we are” and reopens internal constitutional disputes (NI alignment to EU rules, etc.).

Northern Ireland arrangements (contest): Protocol/Windsor Framework as amended treaty-internal market compromise; democratic consent mechanism and continued contestation.

- Sovereignty grammar: NI arrangements can be framed as unacceptable internal border or as necessary compromise to protect peace and the UK internal market (internal tension).
- Economic integration grammar: NI is a live example of how market access reduces friction; dual access can be framed as economic advantage.
- Identity/union grammar: NI is a core site where Brexit redefines sovereignty, consent, and state legitimacy.

Grammar specifications

Why three grammars

Three grammars are sufficient to capture the dominant interpretive “attractors” in British and international Brexit discourse without collapsing into either (a) an unmanageably large taxonomy or (b) a false binary of “Leave vs Remain”. The chosen three map to distinct primary variables that generate genuinely different closures:

- **Sovereignty–constitutional autonomy** (Brexit as self-rule).
- **Economic integration–material welfare** (Brexit as friction and productivity shock).
- **Identity–legitimacy–territorial cohesion** (Brexit as meaning conflict and constitutional stressor).

A plausible **emergent** fourth grammar exists (a “pragmatic reset / managed interdependence” grammar), visible after the 2025 UK–EU summit’s technocratic cooperation agenda (SPS alignment, youth mobility schemes, etc.).

It is flagged under boundaries as a potential future crystallisation, but the core analysis remains tri-grammatical.

Grammar one: Sovereignty–constitutional autonomy grammar

Primary analytical variable: Control of law and borders through sovereign political authority (Parliamentary/constitutional self-government).

Signal selection rules:
Admits as primary: constitutional constraints (Miller), treaty status, regulatory autonomy (REUL reforms), formal end of EU legal supremacy, border/migration regime design, and symbolic autonomy markers (ability to legislate, sign treaties). Economic signals are admitted but often reclassified as *transitional* or *implementation-contingent*.

Weighting priority:

1. Constitutional authority and democratic legitimacy, 2) boundaries/control (migration regime), 3) regulatory divergence capacity, 4) geopolitical and treaty autonomy, 5) economic outcomes as secondary (unless catastrophic).

Causal chain type:
Normative-constitutional with instrumental spillovers. The grammar constructs explanations like: *Loss of control → democratic deficit → mandate for exit → regained policy capacity → long-run national renewal*, with setbacks attributed to transition or sabotage.

Admissible closure:
Permitted conclusions typically include: “Brexit was necessary/justified”; “Brexit benefits realised over time”; “problems are due to implementation choices, not the decision”; “closer cooperation is acceptable only if it preserves sovereignty”. A conclusion of “Brexit was a fundamental mistake requiring rejoin” is generally inadmissible except at the grammar boundary.

Excluded signals (recommended):
Often suppresses counterfactual GDP-loss models, comparative welfare benchmarking, and trade-friction metrics that imply structural loss rather than transitional cost. It may also suppress identity polarisation data if it threatens “national unity” narratives.

Characteristic vocabulary (recommended):
“Take back control”, “sovereignty”, “self-government”, “democratic deficit”, “unelected bureaucrats”, “global Britain”, “regulatory freedoms”, “independent trade policy”, “border control”.

Temporal orientation (recommended):
Primarily **forward-prescriptive**: evaluates Brexit as an enabling condition whose payoff is future-oriented.

Temporal formation (recommended):
Crystallised during the **pre-2016 and 2016 referendum period**, with later evidence often processed as either confirmation (ability to reform REUL) or damage-control (economic friction blamed on policy choices or external shocks).

Grammar boundary specification:
This grammar transforms into the economic integration grammar when it concedes that **economic welfare**

is causally fundamental and that sovereignty is instrumentally valuable only when it maximises prosperity. It transforms into the identity/legitimacy grammar when it admits that sovereignty claims are primarily **recognition narratives** rather than institutional control mechanisms.

Source tradition:
British Euroscepticism, parliamentary sovereignty doctrine, populist-democratic rhetoric, and certain strands of realist statecraft.

Grammar two: Economic integration–material welfare grammar

Primary analytical variable: Economic openness / integration intensity (trade costs, investment, productivity) as the main driver of welfare and state capacity.

Signal selection rules:
Admits as primary: GDP (levels and per head), trade volumes with EU vs non-EU, sector performance (manufacturing/services), regulatory divergence as a cost driver, and migration as labour supply/human capital. Constitutional signals are admitted mainly as drivers of policy choices that affect integration.

Weighting priority:

1. Productivity and real income per head, 2) trade and investment capacity, 3) regulatory/stability signals affecting business expectations, 4) institutional cooperation where it reduces transaction costs.

Causal chain type:
Structural-economic with counterfactual reasoning. Typical chain: *Exit from single market/customs union → higher non-tariff barriers → lower trade/investment → weaker productivity → weaker GDP per head → fiscal and distributional strain*, with downstream political consequences.

Admissible closure:
Usually permits: “Brexit reduced UK prosperity relative to a plausible remain counterfactual”; “closer alignment would improve outcomes”; “some independence benefits exist but are outweighed by frictions”. A closure that “Brexit is an unambiguous success” is generally inadmissible unless the signal set reverses dramatically.

Excluded signals (recommended):
Tends to downweight sovereignty-as-intrinsic-value signals, symbolic cultural gains, and “freedom” narratives unless operationalised into measurable outcomes.

Characteristic vocabulary (recommended):
“Friction”, “non-tariff barriers”, “single market”, “customs union”, “productivity”, “investment”, “trade intensity”, “regulatory alignment”, “market access”, “opportunity cost”.

Temporal orientation (recommended):
Mixed **backward-counterfactual** (what would have happened under remain) and **forward-optimising** (what policy alignment could recover).

Temporal formation (recommended):
Crystallised strongly during **2015–2016** with forecast-based arguments; later evidence is processed as confirmation or as partial adjustment (e.g., UK–EU “reset” as mitigation).

Grammar boundary specification:
Transforms into the sovereignty grammar if it concludes that long-run welfare depends more on autonomous policy experimentation than integration; transforms into identity/legitimacy grammar if it decides economic outcomes matter mainly through their role in status conflict and political cohesion.

Source tradition:
International political economy, trade economics, pro-integration liberal institutionalism, business and Treasury-style cost–benefit frameworks.

Grammar three: Identity–legitimacy–territorial cohesion grammar

Primary analytical variable: Legitimacy and recognition within a multi-level polity (who belongs, who is heard, and whether governance feels "ours"), including territorial integrity of the UK.

Signal selection rules:
Admits as primary: trust/distrust, polarisation, identity salience, constitutional stability signals (Scotland independence polling; NI consent conflict), and narrative conflicts from campaign and governance controversies. Economic and migration signals are admitted as catalysts for meaning-making and legitimacy crises (e.g., "betrayal", "broken promises"), not as sufficient explanations.

Weighting priority:

1. Legitimacy/trust, 2) territorial cohesion (NI/Scotland), 3) identity boundary management, 4) economic conditions insofar as they reshape status and consent.

Causal chain type:
Hermeneutic–socio-political with feedback loops. Typical chain: *Identity cleavage + perceived misrecognition → referendum as symbolic revolt → prolonged conflict → erosion of trust → constitutional and territorial stress → policy volatility → further identity hardening*.

Admissible closure:
Permits: "Brexit is a continuing identity settlement crisis"; "economic debates are proxy wars for recognition"; "policy 'resets' can reduce friction but not heal meaning conflict"; "closure requires legitimacy rebuilding more than technocratic fixes".

Excluded signals (recommended):
May suppress fine-grained macro debates that do not translate into lived meaning or political identity. It can also suppress some sovereignty claims by treating them as rhetoric rather than causal substance.

Characteristic vocabulary (recommended):
"Polarisation", "betrayal", "recognition", "legitimacy", "identity", "union", "consent", "culture war", "centre–periphery", "Englishness/Britishness", "status".

Temporal orientation (recommended):
Primarily **lateral-hermeneutic** (how the present is interpreted) with attention to historical roots (post-imperial identity; deindustrialisation) and future risks (union break-up).

Temporal formation (recommended):
Crystallised after **2016–2019**, as Brexit identities hardened and parliamentary stalemate/implementation conflict became a narrative engine; later evidence is processed as confirmation of enduring cleavage, even when material outcomes swing.

Grammar boundary specification:
Transforms into economic grammar if identity is treated as epiphenomenal to material conditions; transforms into sovereignty grammar if legitimacy is equated with "formal control" rather than perceived recognition.

Source tradition:
Political sociology, nationalism studies, legitimacy theory, political psychology of polarisation, centre–periphery and multinational state analysis.

Signal processing

What follows are three independent processing essays. Each holds the signal set constant and applies different grammar rules. Counter-signals are integrated *within* processing.

Sovereignty–constitutional autonomy processing

The sovereign-autonomy grammar begins by treating the 2016 referendum as a decisive legitimacy event: a mass act of democratic self-determination, albeit narrow, that yielded a clear binary outcome—Leave at 51.9% vs Remain at 48.1% with high turnout (72.2%).

In this grammar, the narrowness does not weaken legitimacy; it intensifies the mandate to **execute** the decision precisely because the act of decision is the fundamental good. The referendum becomes less a utilitarian optimisation problem and more a constitutional instruction: *the people have chosen the location of authority*.

Immediately, however, the grammar encounters a counter-signal: the campaign governance controversies (Vote Leave sanctions and referrals).

In an autonomy grammar, this is uncomfortable because it threatens the purity of the mandate. Two stabilising moves are common. One is to class such breaches as **procedural imperfections** that do not invalidate a nationwide vote. The other is to reframe the controversy as evidence of the need for *stronger domestic governance*—a “we must fix our own democratic machinery” lesson rather than a reason to reverse the decision. The key is that the ultimate authority is still domestic; the scandal becomes inward-facing.

The Miller litigation is processed as a confirmation of the grammar’s deepest premise: that constitutional sovereignty resides in Parliament and constitutional procedure, not executive fiat. The Supreme Court’s majority held that an Act of Parliament was required to authorise the Article 50 notice.

Far from undermining Brexit, this is read as the system demonstrating that Brexit is being achieved **through** constitutional self-government. Yet the same event also contains a latent internal tension: the “people’s vote” required Parliamentary enactment, which some proponents interpret as establishment resistance. The grammar resolves this by holding both: *constitutional form must be respected* and *political elites must not obstruct the people’s will*. In other words, Parliament is sovereign, but it must morally follow the referendum instruction.

From here, treaties are interpreted as boundary markers of autonomy. The Withdrawal Agreement entering into force (1 Feb 2020) is read as the formal completion of departure and the start of building a new relationship on a sovereign-to-sovereign basis, including the difficult but necessary Protocol arrangements for Northern Ireland.

The TCA’s timing (signed Dec 2020; provisional Jan 2021; in force May 2021) is processed as especially important: it marks the creation of a new legal architecture in which the UK chooses alignment as a policy variable rather than as an obligation of membership. At this point the trade and GDP signals arrive—but the grammar’s selection rules demote them. ONS reports modest GDP growth: +1.3% in 2025, with 0.1% growth in Q4 2025 and no growth in services that quarter (while production rose 1.2%). The autonomy grammar does not deny these figures; it reclassifies them as (a) post-shock macro conditions and (b) partly transitional effects of shifting legal regimes. The “real GDP per head fell 0.1% for the second consecutive quarter” is acknowledged, but treated as a policy challenge rather than as a referendum refutation. Trade signals are handled similarly. The Commons Library notes that the EU remains a major trade partner (2024 exports to EU £358bn; imports from EU £454bn), and also that goods exports to the EU in 2024 are still 18% below 2019 in real terms, while services exports to the EU are 19% above 2019. The sovereignty

grammar emphasises two aspects: first, the very fact that the UK trades heavily with the EU proves that independence does not equal isolation; second, services resilience becomes a counter-signal against claims of economic collapse. Goods underperformance is processed as partly attributable to non-Brexit shocks, and partly as a short-term adjustment to new border processes. The structural break in goods trade data after January 2021, explicitly noted by the Commons Library, is employed rhetorically to reduce confidence in simple “before/after” comparisons. A particularly useful “signal about signals” for this grammar is the OSR critique of monthly trade-in-services estimates: large revisions and potential bias can make monthly services trade “limited value”.

This does not necessarily undermine the “services resilience” counter-signal (which is framed in annual/real-term comparisons), but it does provide an epistemic permission structure: critics’ trade claims are treated as overconfident, and the prudent sovereign response is to focus on **capability-building** rather than on contested short-run series.

Migration is a central sovereignty variable because it speaks directly to borders. ONS shows net migration fell dramatically to 204,000 by YE June 2025, down from 944,000 in YE March 2023, and that EU+ and British net migration are negative while non-EU+ remains positive.

The grammar interprets this as evidence that the UK can now **design** migration (especially by changing composition) in line with national preference, even if total numbers remain politically contested. The fall is treated as a counter-signal against claims that Brexit permanently failed to restore border control. At the same time, an internal vulnerability appears: the earlier peak (YE March 2023) can be re-read as “loss of control persists”. The grammar typically resolves this by blaming domestic policy choices (visa routes, enforcement) rather than EU exit itself: *Brexit made control possible; government must use it properly.*

Regulatory divergence is where autonomy grammar seeks its clearest confirmation. The Commons Library notes that REUL ceased as a special category on 1 January 2024, becoming “assimilated law”, and that the REUL dashboard contains 6,757 pieces with a reform roadmap to June 2026.

This is processed as the institutionalisation of “taking back control” in legal form: the UK can now actively prune, amend, and replace EU-derived rules. The fact that nearly 67% remains unchanged is not necessarily damaging; it can be framed as sovereign choice to retain what works. Northern Ireland is the sovereignty grammar’s hardest test because it concentrates sovereignty contradictions. The Protocol (in force from 1 Jan 2021) applies EU single market rules for goods in NI to avoid a hard border on the island; the Windsor Framework amends the Protocol; and Safeguarding the Union (Jan 2024) made further operational changes tied to restoring devolved institutions. This grammar can process NI in two competing sub-ways. One treats any internal UK regulatory border as a sovereignty violation; the other treats NI arrangements as a necessary peace-and-trade compromise within a sovereign strategy. The democratic consent vote in Dec 2024 (continuation supported, per reporting) and the UK government’s framing of it as a stabilising step allow the grammar to claim: the UK is managing its internal settlement under domestic constitutional authority, even if contested.

Still, this remains a leakage point: sovereignty is not uniform across territory.

The UK–EU “reset” summit of May 2025 is processed ambivalently. The Common Understanding includes ambitions such as a youth experience scheme, Erasmus+ association talks, and—most controversially for hard sovereigntists—an SPS agreement requiring “timely dynamic alignment” with EU rules in covered areas.

The grammar can accept such cooperation only if it preserves ultimate UK decision authority; dynamic alignment threatens to look like rule-taking. Therefore, the reset is either reframed as (a) sovereign bargaining for mutual benefit or (b) a boundary breach toward reintegration. This is precisely where an **emergent pragmatic grammar** begins to appear: some actors accept Brexit as settled but pursue deep technocratic cooperation to reduce frictions—without openly rejoining.

Finally, legitimacy and identity signals: NatCen's BSA reporting indicates historically high dissatisfaction with governance (79% say the system could be improved "quite a lot/a great deal"), and it records sharp rises in distrust, including among Leave voters, with one measure showing the share of Leave voters who felt Brexit strengthened law-making falling from 85% (2019) to 47% (2024).

The sovereignty grammar reads this as evidence that Brexit has not yet been translated into felt sovereignty for many—an implementation and delivery failure rather than a conceptual error. It therefore calls for decisive domestic reform and visible use of regulatory freedoms.

Closure (sovereignty grammar): Brexit is primarily validated as a constitutional reassertion of self-government, with economic and administrative frictions treated as secondary and correctable through better domestic choices. The most serious structural risk is territorial: Northern Ireland arrangements and continuing Scottish constitutional volatility indicate that "sovereignty regained" is unevenly distributed and may destabilise the union.

Economic integration–material welfare processing

The economic integration grammar begins from a different axiom: the referendum is not the core object; the core object is the UK's **economic capacity** under alternative institutional regimes. The 2016 vote is still a major signal—51.9% Leave, 48.1% Remain, turnout 72.2%—but it is treated as an initiating shock rather than as a decisive reason-marker.

A narrow majority is important here because it suggests the policy shift may lack the social consensus needed to support long-run investment confidence and stable implementation.

Campaign governance controversies (Vote Leave sanctions) are not usually central in this grammar but function as a risk amplifier: perceived procedural or ethical controversy raises the perceived volatility of the political environment.

Volatility matters because investment is forward-looking; even if the vote stands, the process can degrade credibility.

The Miller judgment is then read not primarily as a sovereignty triumph but as a **predictability signal**: constitutional constraints required Parliamentary authorisation, implying a rule-bound process that reduces the probability of arbitrary executive action.

That stabilises expectations. However, it also illustrates the underlying problem: constitutional conflict over the exit path prolonged uncertainty, which the economic grammar treats as costly.

Treaty architecture is decisive. The Withdrawal Agreement (in force 1 Feb 2020) and the TCA (in force 1 May 2021, with provisional application from 1 Jan 2021) represent a fundamental shift: the UK moved from being inside the EU single market and customs union to being outside, with "zero-tariff, zero-quota" goods trade but more barriers, especially non-tariff frictions.

The grammar treats this as the central causal hinge: **institutional distance increases trade costs**, and trade costs feed productivity, investment, and real income per head.

GDP signals are therefore heavily weighted. ONS reports annual GDP growth of 1.3% in 2025, and quarterly growth of 0.1% in Q4 2025.

The grammar does not claim this is "Brexit alone", but it treats sluggish growth as consistent with a scenario in which the UK shifted to a lower trade-intensity equilibrium. The real GDP per head signal is particularly load-bearing: the ONS reports real GDP per head fell again (0.1%) for the second consecutive quarter in Q4 2025, though it rose annually by 1.0% in 2025.

Per-head measures are the grammar's preferred welfare anchor; they speak to living standards rather than aggregate scale.

Trade volumes then provide the mechanism. The Commons Library reports that in 2024 the EU accounted for £358bn of UK exports of goods and services (41% of all exports) and £454bn of imports (51% of all imports).

For this grammar, the EU share is not merely descriptive—it indicates that the UK's nearest large market remains central, so adding frictions there is structurally costly. The additional detail that goods exports to the EU remain 18% below 2019 levels in real terms is interpreted as evidence consistent with persistent post-transition friction. Now the counter-signal arrives: services exports have performed better, with services exports to the EU 19% above 2019 levels (real) and to non-EU 23% above.

Rather than denying this, the economic grammar uses it to refine the closure: Brexit's costs may fall disproportionately on goods-intensive sectors and SMEs, while globally tradable services show resilience. The grammar thus expects distributional and sectoral asymmetry: some regions and sectors hurt more than others.

However, the grammar must also confront signal contestation. The Commons Library notes that Brexit changed the collection of goods trade data and created a structural break from January 2021.

Meanwhile, the OSR warns that monthly trade-in-services estimates have large revisions and potential bias, limiting their use.

The economic grammar responds not by abandoning trade evidence but by triangulating: it relies on *institutional reasoning* (exit from single market implies non-tariff barriers), and on higher-level patterns (multi-year real-term comparisons) rather than month-to-month volatility. The OSR critique becomes a methodological caution rather than an exculpation.

Migration is processed primarily as labour supply, human capital, and public service pressure. ONS shows net migration fell to 204,000 by YE June 2025, down dramatically from YE March 2023 (944,000), with non-EU+ net migration still positive and EU+ net migration negative.

In the economic grammar, this is not immediately "good" or "bad"; it depends on composition (skills, sector needs) and on whether reductions exacerbate labour shortages or relieve service pressures. The critical interpretive move is that Brexit replaced a flexible EU labour supply channel with a more bureaucratically mediated system, often increasing adjustment costs in sectors that relied on EU mobility. Even if net migration is still positive, *the matching mechanism changed*.

Regulatory divergence is mostly interpreted as a transaction-cost variable and a credibility variable. REUL becoming "assimilated law" and the active reform roadmap through June 2026 is therefore ambiguous.

If divergence is targeted and improves productivity, it could be beneficial; if it fragments standards relative to the EU, it increases compliance costs and reduces market access. The fact that nearly 67% remains unchanged is interpreted as evidence that "regulatory freedom" does not automatically generate productivity-enhancing reform; it often generates administrative work without clear growth payoff. This interpretation is reinforced by the UK–EU reset's design: the Common Understanding explicitly contemplates **dynamic alignment** in an SPS agreement and in energy market arrangements.

From an economic integration perspective, that is an implicit admission that alignment reduces friction and is therefore economically valuable—even at the price of partial rule-following.

Northern Ireland is read as a natural experiment within the UK: the Protocol/Windsor Framework keeps NI aligned with EU goods rules to avoid a hard border, while Great Britain diverges.

The economic grammar therefore expects: (a) lower friction for NI–EU goods movement and (b) friction within the UK internal market (GB–NI). This is not merely conceptual; it has institutional consequences, prompting repeated renegotiation and the Safeguarding the Union adjustments. The democratic consent vote continuing the arrangements (Dec 2024) functions as a stabilisation signal: the system is politically contested but institutionally persistent, which markets typically prefer over constant renegotiation risk. Scotland's independence polling (Ipsos: 51% Yes vs 49% No among likely Yes/No in Feb 2026) is processed not primarily as identity drama but as an economic risk premium: constitutional uncertainty increases the discount rate on investment and complicates long-run fiscal planning.

Brexit's role is that it reactivated sovereignty questions and created divergent territorial preferences (e.g., Scotland's EU orientation vs UK-wide exit), increasing the salience of secession.

Institutional trust is interpreted as both outcome and driver. NatCen reports record-level dissatisfaction with governance (79% say it needs significant improvement) and high distrust measures; importantly, it notes rising disenchantment among Leave voters and that perceptions of Brexit strengthening law-making declined sharply among Leave voters between 2019 and 2024.

For economic integration grammar, this matters because low trust reduces policy credibility and increases the difficulty of long-run, growth-oriented reform. Even if Brexit were reversible in principle, the grammar predicts that the feasibility of rejoining or deep alignment depends on rebuilding trust and stable state capacity.

Finally, everyday-friction symbolic signals—such as the EU Entry/Exit System starting in October 2025 with full phased operation expected by April 2026—are treated as small economic frictions but large political irritants: micro-costs that shape public feeling about the value of integration.

Counter-signals are integrated into the closure: CPTPP accession (effective by 15 Dec 2024) supports a "diversification" narrative. But the economic grammar weights it modestly relative to EU trade because the EU remains roughly half of imports and a large share of exports; geography and supply-chain density matter. The UK–EU reset is therefore interpreted as partial convergence driven by economic necessity: the UK seeks to reduce barriers (SPS, energy market pathways) while preserving political red lines.

Closure (economic integration grammar): Brexit is best explained as an institutional distancing that raised trade and regulatory frictions with the UK's principal nearby market, producing a persistent drag on productivity and per-head welfare and generating constitutional risk (NI/Scotland) that further undermines investment confidence. Improvements are possible through managed alignment ("reset"), but deep trade-offs remain: the more sovereignty is exercised as divergence, the more friction is generated; the more friction is reduced through dynamic alignment, the more sovereignty becomes nominal.

Identity–legitimacy–territorial cohesion processing

The identity–legitimacy grammar treats the referendum not as a policy choice but as a **symbolic and recognition event**. The Electoral Commission's formal result—51.9% Leave vs 48.1% Remain—matters primarily because it reveals a divided polity whose "we" is unstable.

The high turnout (72.2%) indicates deep mobilisation around identity and belonging rather than ordinary "low-salience" policy-making. Campaign governance controversies (Vote Leave sanctions; broader complaints about misleadingness recorded in the referendum administration report) are interpreted as accelerants of legitimacy crisis. In this grammar, the point is not whether the vote is legally valid; it is that contested truthfulness and rule-breaches become proof-texts in rival moral narratives ("stolen mandate" vs "elite trying to reverse the people"). The Electoral Commission's own reporting that it received substantial complaints about campaign conduct and that perceptions of fairness were contested becomes part of the story that Brexit is an argument about truth and trust as much as about Europe. The Miller decision is read as a key moment of ontological divergence: one interpretive community experiences the need for

Parliamentary authorisation as constitutional propriety; another experiences it as thwarting the “people’s will”. The Supreme Court press summary explicitly frames the question as constitutional requirements and holds that Parliament must authorise Article 50 notice.

The identity grammar highlights the emotional translation: the same institutional act can be processed as “democracy upheld” or “democracy denied”, depending on whether democracy is equated with parliamentary procedure or plebiscitary sovereignty.

Treaty milestones (Withdrawal Agreement 2020; TCA 2021) matter in this grammar less as trade arrangements and more as **meaning locks**: they formalise a new relationship that many citizens did not choose, forcing identity renegotiation.

This grammar predicts that once identities harden (“Leaver/Remainer” as social identities), later policy detail is often interpreted through group loyalty rather than evidence.

Institutional trust signals are therefore primary. NatCen reports that 79% say Britain’s system of governing needs substantial improvement (matching the record low seen during the 2019 Brexit stalemate), alongside record highs in distrust measures.

Crucially, it notes “sharp rise in disenchantment among Leave voters” and that the proportion of Leave voters who felt Brexit strengthened law-making fell from 85% in 2019 to 47% in 2024.

This is a central identity-grammar mechanism: Brexit promised recognition (“control”), but for many the lived experience is continued powerlessness, producing betrayal narratives *within* the original Brexit coalition.

Economic and migration signals are processed as legitimacy fuel. GDP growth of 1.3% in 2025 and recurrent weak per-head signals are not decisive as economic facts; they are decisive insofar as they interact with expectations.

If Brexit was imagined as national revival, sluggish growth becomes evidence of “broken promise”; if Brexit was imagined as self-harm, sluggish growth becomes evidence of “predictable damage”. The same macro signal thus reinforces opposite narratives because the grammar weights it primarily as a meaning-confirmation device.

Trade signals likewise enter as lived-friction stories. The Commons Library notes ongoing differences: goods exports to EU below 2019 levels, services exports above; and it explicitly cautions that COVID, Ukraine, and supply chain disruption complicate interpretation, alongside a structural break in goods trade data from January 2021.

The identity grammar uses the “structural break” not as a technical note but as a metaphor: Brexit created a break in how the country “counts” its relationship to Europe. The OSR critique of trade-in-services revisions becomes part of a broader “epistemic distrust” environment: if even the numbers cannot settle arguments, polarisation persists. Migration is a classic identity-boundary signal. ONS reports net migration fell sharply to 204,000 by YE June 2025, while non-EU+ net migration remained positive and EU+ net migration was negative. The identity grammar does not read this simply as “control regained” or “labour supply adjusted”; it reads it as boundary renegotiation and shifting symbolic targets. Ending EU free movement changes not only numbers but the social meaning of “who comes” and “under what terms”. The large fall in total net migration after the 2023 peak becomes a narrative battleground: one side sees proof that policy can bite; another sees evidence that earlier chaos was needless; both sides find confirmation. Territorial politics are central: Brexit reactivated the question “what is the UK?” Northern Ireland is the most intense site of ontological divergence because it forces incompatible goods into one framework: avoiding a hard border on the island of Ireland, preserving the UK internal market, and respecting competing identities and the peace settlement. The Commons Library describes how the Protocol applied EU single market rules for goods in NI to avoid a hard border and how the Windsor Framework is the amended Protocol; it also documents how

the DUP's opposition suspended institutions and how Safeguarding the Union (Jan 2024) was tied to restoration.

In identity grammar terms, NI arrangements are not a technical trade fix—they are a legitimacy struggle over sovereignty, consent, and symbolic belonging.

The democratic consent vote of Dec 2024, continuing Articles 5–10 arrangements, is therefore not just an institutional step; it is a ritual reaffirmation that remains deeply divided (as reflected in reporting of the vote split).

The grammar highlights that "consent" itself is contested: unionists may reject the arrangement as undermining their British identity, while others treat it as protecting peace and prosperity. Brexit thus produces continuing symbolic injury even when procedures function.

Scotland's independence temperature is then interpreted as a legitimacy spillover. Ipsos finds 51% Yes vs 49% No among likely referendum voters in Feb 2026.

In identity grammar, this is not merely "risk"; it is evidence that Brexit loosened the emotional glue of the union by changing the perceived direction of national identity (towards or away from Europe) and by re-legitimising sovereignty claims at sub-state level. Brexit creates a template: if sovereignty can be reclaimed from Brussels, why not from Westminster?

Regulatory divergence functions here as identity theatre as much as policy. The REUL/assimilated law shift and the explicit government rhetoric about "regulatory freedoms post-Brexit" are cultural signals: they indicate an attempt to materialise sovereignty in law and to narrate a post-EU national identity.

Yet the same signal can generate alienation where divergence threatens rights, standards, or cross-border identities (especially in NI, where alignment with EU goods rules is built into the settlement). The 2025 UK–EU summit "reset" is particularly revealing in identity terms. The Common Understanding emphasises "people-to-people ties" (a youth experience scheme) and even UK association to Erasmus+, while also acknowledging that "smooth border management" and eGate use depend on the EU Entry/Exit System. This indicates a partial cultural re-Europeanisation even after formal exit. But it also risks re-triggering sovereignty anxieties, because the same document openly contemplates dynamic alignment in covered areas (SPS agreement; electricity market).

The identity grammar predicts that technocratic cooperation will not automatically heal polarisation; it may instead be read as betrayal (by sovereigntists) or as insufficient repair (by reintegrationists). Thus, the reset is a new theatre for the same identity struggle.

Counter-signals are crucial: CPTPP accession (effective by Dec 2024) is processed as a symbolic "Global Britain" victory for some, but for others it reads as elite narrative management (a small substitute for EU integration).

The fact that EU travel frictions are institutionalised through systems like EES (phased to April 2026) becomes a quotidian reminder of separation.

Closure (identity–legitimacy grammar): Brexit is best understood as an ongoing legitimacy and recognition conflict in a multinational state. Economic and trade signals matter mainly as narrative resources that reinforce group identities. The deepest consequences are constitutional and cultural: sustained distrust, polarisation, and territorial stress (NI settlement contestation; Scotland's near-even independence polling). Technocratic "resets" can reduce practical harms but cannot conclude the meaning conflict without legitimacy rebuilding and a shared story of the polity.

Closure comparison

This section compares the closures across seven dimensions and performs an ontological check.

Closure content

- **Sovereignty closure:** Brexit justified as democratic–constitutional self-rule; costs are transitional/contingent; the task is to *use* regained powers effectively.

Signal divergence

All grammars accept the referendum result, treaty timeline, and core macro facts, but they diverge on what those facts *mean*. For example, ONS GDP growth of 1.3% in 2025 is:

- “Not decisive; sovereignty more fundamental” (sovereignty grammar).

Exclusion patterns

- Sovereignty grammar tends to exclude or downweight counterfactual economic costing and treats OSR/measurement caveats as permission to avoid strong economic inferences.
- Economic grammar excludes sovereignty-as-intrinsic-value and reclassifies it as rhetorical unless operationalised into governance improvements.
- Identity grammar excludes detailed macro adjudication where it does not translate into legitimacy outcomes; it keeps trust and territorial signals central.

Causal architecture

- **Sovereignty:** constitutional-normative causality → policy capacity → future outcomes.
- **Economic:** structural trade-cost causality → productivity/income → fiscal and political effects.
- **Identity:** hermeneutic feedback causality → polarisation/trust → constitutional instability → policy volatility.

These are not merely different *answers*; they are different *explanation machines*.

Closure range

Admissible conclusions differ sharply.

- Sovereignty grammar can accept a “reset” only if it preserves a sovereignty narrative, but struggles to permit “rejoin” closure.
- Identity grammar permits neither simple reversal nor simple vindication; it expects durable cleavage and therefore emphasises legitimacy repair.

Closure timing

- Sovereignty grammar crystallised around 2016 and tends to treat later evidence as implementation noise or as delayed payoff.

Grammar translation

Sovereignty → Economic: “They are measuring Britain’s freedom with the wrong yardstick; short-term GDP noise cannot outweigh democratic self-rule.”
Economic → Sovereignty: “They call it ‘control’, but they accept dynamic alignment when costs bite; sovereignty is being traded back for market access.”

Identity → Sovereignty: “Sovereignty talk is the language of recognition; people wanted dignity and voice, not merely legal competencies.”
Identity → Economic: “Economic numbers are weapons in a status war; what matters is whether people feel heard and whether the union holds.”
Economic → Identity: “Polarisation is partly endogenous to material strain and uncertainty; reduce frictions and you lower the political temperature.”
Sovereignty → Identity: “Polarisation is what happens when elites refuse to respect democratic decisions; legitimacy returns when the mandate is honoured.”

Ontological check

Do the grammars analyse the same phenomenon? Partly—but not fully.

- Sovereignty grammar analyses **where authority should sit**.
- Economic grammar analyses **how institutional form shapes welfare and capacity**.
- Identity grammar analyses **what Brexit means for belonging and legitimacy in a multinational state**.

They overlap in the referent “Brexit” but often operate on different ontological objects: *constitutional location of rule*, *economic integration regime*, and *identity settlement*. This ontological slippage is itself a major driver of interpretive conflict.

Counter-signals, leakage, and stress test

Consolidated counter-signals

The counter-signals most relevant across grammars are:

- **Services trade resilience**: UK services exports recovered strongly; 2024 services exports to EU and non-EU are above 2019 in real terms.

Leakage

Leakage is where a grammar’s exclusions fail and inconvenient signals force themselves back in.

- **Sovereignty grammar leakage:**
    - Trust collapse among Leave voters is hard to dismiss because it threatens the claim that Brexit restored felt control. NatCen reports large declines in Leave voters’ belief that Brexit strengthened law-making, and overall governance dissatisfaction at 79%.

Economic grammar leakage:

- Services resilience and diversification signals (CPTPP; services exports above 2019) prevent a totalising “all harm” story.

Identity grammar leakage:

- Pure meaning analysis can be threatened by evidence of institutional adaptation and “reset” pragmatism—suggesting polarisation might soften through cooperation.

- Hard macro deterioration would force identity grammar to concede material causality; conversely, sustained growth would force it to explain persistent division despite improving conditions.

Grammar stress test

For each grammar, identify the most threatening counter-signal and how it stresses closure.

Sovereignty grammar stressor: *Dynamic alignment in the 2025 reset agenda (SPS agreement and electricity market cooperation).*
The Common Understanding explicitly envisions “timely dynamic alignment” with EU rules in covered areas.

This threatens the closure because it can look like rule-taking—precisely what Brexit was meant to escape. The grammar must say either (a) alignment is sovereign choice (therefore not a sovereignty loss) or (b) reset is betrayal/creep toward reintegration. Either move narrows closure coherence.

Economic grammar stressor: *Services resilience + successful diversification narratives.*
Services exports outperform goods and rose above 2019 levels, and CPTPP accession provides a concrete diversification milestone.

These do not refute cost arguments, but they weaken maximalist closures (“Brexit has been wholly economically catastrophic”) and force the grammar into a more nuanced sectoral/distributional conclusion.

Identity grammar stressor: *Evidence of stabilising adaptation (NI consent functioning; reset cooperation).*
The NI consent process continued arrangements and the UK government framed it as a step forward; the 2025 reset emphasises people-to-people and friction-reducing cooperation.

This stresses the claim that Brexit is locked into perpetual conflict. The grammar must distinguish between operational stabilisation and meaning resolution—arguing that institutions can function while legitimacy conflict remains.

Post-analysis reflexive note and methodological observations

Post-analysis reflexive note

Revisiting Step 0, my home-grammar tendency toward economic integration analysis did indeed shape what felt “solid” and what felt “contestable”. GDP, trade, and regulatory alignment provided the clearest structured causal chains, especially given the availability of authoritative sources (ONS, Commons Library, OSR).

However, running the sovereignty grammar faithfully clarified a key methodological point: for many actors, Brexit is not an optimisation problem but a category claim about where legitimate authority resides. The Miller case, for example, is not merely a procedural fact; it is a narrative generator about democracy’s true locus.

The hardest grammar to operate remained the sovereignty grammar, but the exercise revealed *why*: it is structurally resistant to being “proven wrong” by economic data because its admissible closure is set by constitutional value premises. Conversely, the identity grammar became more intelligible than I expected once institutional trust signals were treated as primary rather than derivative; NatCen’s evidence of record

governance dissatisfaction and shifting Leave-voter perceptions functions as a core legitimacy indicator, not an afterthought.

Blind spots discovered: I initially underweighted how **signal quality disputes** (OSR on trade statistics revisions) become political resources—epistemic uncertainty itself fuels divergence by allowing each grammar to claim the other is “cherry-picking”. I also see more clearly that a pragmatic “reset” grammar may be emerging: the 2025 Common Understanding contains a cooperation blueprint (youth experience schemes, Erasmus+, SPS alignment) that neither fully repudiates Brexit nor fully celebrates divergence.

If the analysis were written from a sovereignty home grammar, the economic and trust signals might be processed more as implementation audits (“did governments use freedom well?”) than as referendum evaluations. If written from an identity home grammar, I would likely treat post-2025 cooperation not as policy mitigation but as a new symbolic battleground in the Brexit culture war.

Methodological observations

The prismatic method worked well here because Brexit is a high-signal, high-contestation phenomenon with multiple plausible “primary variables”. Holding the signal set constant exposed that divergence is driven less by different facts than by different **admission rules** and **weight hierarchies**.

Two difficulties stood out.

First, **signal contestation is itself a signal**. The OSR critique of trade-in-services revisions and the Commons Library’s warning about structural breaks in trade data are not mere footnotes; they actively shape what grammars permit themselves to conclude.

The method benefits from explicitly including such meta-signals early (as done here).

Second, **ontological slippage** is pervasive. “Brexit” names overlapping but different objects (sovereignty location, integration regime, identity settlement). The method requires recurrent ontological checks, otherwise grammar comparison becomes unfair: one grammar may be answering a different question while appearing to “disagree”.

Refinement suggestion: incorporate a formal step that forces each grammar to state, in one sentence, *what phenomenon it believes Brexit primarily is*, and then to map which signals it treats as constitutive vs merely consequential. This would prevent hidden phenomenon-switching during processing.

A further refinement: treat “closure timing” as an explicit parameter not only historically (“when did it form?”) but functionally (“what kinds of future evidence would actually revise closure?”). Brexit discourse shows that many grammars have **high closure rigidity**: new evidence is often assimilated as confirmation or blamed on implementation rather than shifting the primary variable. The method could quantify closure rigidity as part of the stress test.

Structural breaks: the House of Commons Library notes a structural break in goods trade data from January 2021 because Brexit changed how EU goods trade data are collected, complicating direct pre/post comparisons.
Attribution disputes: GDP growth and productivity debates hinge on what part of sluggish growth is “Brexit” versus other macro forces.
Economic closure: Brexit is an institutional distancing that structurally raises frictions with the UK’s largest proximate market, reducing productivity and welfare relative to remain; mitigation requires alignment trade-offs.
Identity closure: Brexit is a continuing legitimacy conflict that reconfigures national identity and strains the union; economic data are secondary to trust and consent dynamics.
“A welfare indicator, possibly below counterfactual” (economic grammar).

“A promise-confirmation/betrayal resource shaping trust” (identity grammar).
Economic grammar can accept closer alignment or even rejoin as rational welfare optimisation, but struggles to accept “Brexit is an unqualified success” closure given trade and GDP-per-head concerns.
Economic grammar crystallised from pre-2016 forecasts and treated post-2021 frictions and growth patterns as confirmation, with 2025 reset as partial correction.
Identity grammar crystallised in 2016–2019 polarisation and remains reinforced by persistent low trust and territorial tensions.
Diversification capacity: CPTPP accession entered into force by 15 Dec 2024, supporting the claim that the UK can pursue an independent trade strategy.
Net migration reversal: net migration fell sharply to 204,000 by YE June 2025 after much higher peaks, complicating simple slogans about control.
Managed reintegration dynamics: the 2025 UK–EU reset includes cooperation plans (youth experience scheme, Erasmus+, SPS via dynamic alignment), implying convergence pressures even after exit.
Institutional functioning under strain: NI’s consent mechanism operated and continuation was agreed (though contested), suggesting partial stabilisation.
NI arrangements leak because they expose non-uniform sovereignty within the UK.
Trade-statistics contestation (OSR) forces epistemic modesty in strong monthly claims.